Usability Study Report: Air India Website vs. Redesigned Flight-Booking Prototype

CCA3 – UI/UX Design | Think-Aloud Study and UX Survey

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1. Objective

This study compared the usability of the original Air India website (www.airindia.com) with a redesigned flight-booking prototype created in Figma. The purpose was to identify friction in the existing booking journey and assess whether the redesign made flight search and selection easier to understand.

2. Method

Five participants completed a think-aloud session. Each participant attempted a flight-booking task on the original website and then on the redesigned prototype, verbalising what they noticed, expected, and found confusing. The task covered entering trip details, searching for flights, selecting a flight/fare, and proceeding towards passenger details. Sessions were transcribed from audio using speech-to-text; therefore, some transcript wording was unclear.

Participants also submitted the provided UX survey comparing the original website and the prototype on 18 criteria, including learnability, usability, navigation, visual hierarchy, accessibility, efficiency, minimalist design, readability, and satisfaction. The email receipts confirm survey submissions, but the receipts available for this report do not preserve the selected numerical ratings. Consequently, no survey averages or quantitative score comparisons are reported.

3. Key Findings from Think-Aloud Sessions

Information overload on the original website was the most consistent concern. Participants described promotional, credit/discount, upgrade, fare-category, and date-related information as distracting or excessive. One participant said that completing a simple booking task took too long because of the amount of information presented.

Navigation and task flow were less predictable for some participants. One participant initially expected to select a flight directly from the earlier area of the page and wanted clearer guidance about where to continue or book. Another noticed that dates not relevant to their chosen trip continued to appear. These comments suggest that the next action and the scope of displayed information could be clearer.

Fare and upgrade choices created mixed reactions. A participant questioned why the website continued to offer an upgrade after a fare category had already been selected. Another participant liked being able to compare Basic, Value, Classic, and Flex fare categories. This indicates that fare options can be useful, but their presentation should avoid repeated or distracting upgrade prompts.

The redesigned prototype was generally preferred in the qualitative feedback. Participants described it as cleaner, easier, more attractive, less overwhelming, and faster to move through. One participant specifically appreciated seeing a smaller set of flight results with filters; another liked that the Continue and Confirm Booking actions made the next step clearer.

Participants also identified opportunities to improve the prototype. One participant noted that the passenger type (for example, adult, child, or senior) was not clearly indicated. Another suggested that the colours could be brighter to support navigation. These comments show that reducing clutter should not remove important booking information or visual guidance.

4. Original Website vs. Prototype

Original Air India website: Participants could use basic controls such as date selection and cabin-class options, and some found passenger-detail entry straightforward. However, several participants reported excessive surrounding information, distracting upgrades/promotions, or uncertainty about the next step.

Redesigned Figma prototype: Participants generally found the layout more focused and the booking flow easier to follow. Flight options and filters appeared easier to scan, and clearer continuation actions reduced uncertainty. The main improvement opportunities were clearer passenger-type selection, sufficiently prominent navigation cues/colour contrast, and ensuring that essential fare and booking information remains visible.

5. Recommendations

1. Prioritise the core booking task and reduce unrelated promotional or credit-card content during flight search.

2. Keep the selected route and dates prominent, and avoid showing irrelevant dates or repeated upgrade prompts after a fare choice.

3. Make the next action explicit at each stage with clear labels such as “Select flight”, “Continue”, and “Passenger details”.

4. Include passenger type clearly and make required fields and booking stages easy to identify.

5. Use colour and visual hierarchy consistently so primary actions stand out, while checking text readability and accessibility.

6. Retain useful fare comparisons and filters, but present them in a compact, scannable format.

6. Conclusion

Across the five think-aloud sessions, the redesigned prototype received more positive qualitative feedback than the original Air India website, particularly for reduced information overload, clearer navigation, and a quicker-feeling booking journey. The sessions also revealed remaining usability issues, especially passenger-type clarity and the need for stronger visual cues. These findings support

the direction of the redesign, but they should be interpreted as feedback from a small convenience sample rather than proof that the prototype is universally better. Numerical survey results should be added once the individual 1–10 ratings are available from the Google Forms response spreadsheet.

7. Limitations

The study included five participants and used speech-to-text transcripts that contained some recognition errors. Participants may have used slightly different routes, dates, or fare choices, so the sessions were not perfectly identical. The Figma prototype is an interactive prototype rather than a live booking service; therefore, the study evaluates the interface flow, not actual payment processing or production performance. The numerical survey selections were not recoverable from the supplied email receipts.